外婆的药箱

一碗汤里的夏天

Grandma's Medicine Chest

A Summer in a Bowl of Soup

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Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 5 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 许乐[1]是北京一所大学医学院的学生，今年二十一岁。暑假刚开始，妈妈就打来电话，说外婆[2]一个人住在广州[3]，年纪大了，希望她去陪外婆住一个多月。许乐本来打算留在学校复习，可是想起来自己已经三年没见过外婆了，就买了去广州的火车票。她没有想到，这个夏天会改变她一直很确定的一些看法。

木头药箱

2 外婆住在老城一座旧楼的三楼。许乐一进门，就闻到一股[4]淡淡的药味。客厅的墙角放着一个深红色的木头箱子，大约半米高，上面有十几个小抽屉[5]。每个抽屉上都贴着一张纸，纸上用毛笔写着字：菊花[6]、陈皮[7]、金银花[8]、红枣[9]……纸已经发黄了。

1 许乐 *Xǔ Lè* Xu Le
2 外婆 *wàipó* grandma (mother's mother)
3 广州 *Guǎngzhōu* Guangzhou
4 股 *gǔ* (measure word for smells)
5 抽屉 *chōuti* drawer
6 菊花 *júhuā* chrysanthemum
7 陈皮 *chénpí* dried tangerine peel
8 金银花 *jīnyínhuā* honeysuckle flower
9 红枣 *hóngzǎo* red date, jujube

Xu Le was a student at the medical school of a university in Beijing, and she was twenty-one this year. The summer holiday had only just begun when her mother called. Grandma lived alone in Guangzhou, she said, and was getting old, and she hoped Xu Le would go and stay with her for a month or so. Xu Le had planned to stay at school and revise, but when she remembered that she hadn't seen her grandmother for three years, she bought a train ticket to Guangzhou. She never imagined that this summer would change some of the views she had always been so sure of. 1

The Wooden Medicine Chest

Grandma lived on the third floor of an old building in the old part of the city. As soon as Xu Le stepped through the door, she caught a faint smell of medicine. In a corner of the living room stood a dark red wooden chest, about half a metre tall, with a dozen or so little drawers. On each drawer a slip of paper was pasted, with characters written in brush: chrysanthemum, dried tangerine peel, honeysuckle, red dates... The paper had already turned yellow. 2

2 “这是外婆[1]的药箱，”外婆一边给她倒水，一边笑着说，“是你外公[2]年轻的时候自己做的，用了快五十年了。”

3 许乐[3]走过去，拉开一个小抽屉[4]，里面是一些干了的黄色小花。她拿了一朵闻了闻，味道很香。“外婆，这些东西您都用来做什么？”说到药箱，外婆的眼睛一下子亮了起来：“用的地方可多了。天热了泡[5]菊花茶[6]，雨水多了就煲[7]汤去去湿气[8]，秋天干了就煮[9]梨水。广州[10]人生活，就是要跟着季节走。”

4 许乐点点头，心里却不太同意。她在医学院学了三年，习惯了看数据、看实验、看证据。在她看来，“去湿气”“下火[11]”这样的说法，好听是好听，就是很难用科学的方法证明。

1 外婆 *wàipó* grandma (mother's mother)
2 外公 *wàigōng* grandpa (mother's father)
3 许乐 *Xǔ Lè* Xu Le
4 抽屉 *chōuti* drawer
5 泡 *pào* to steep (tea)
6 菊花茶 *júhuāchá* chrysanthemum tea
7 煲 *bāo* to slow-cook (Cantonese)
8 湿气 *shīqì* "dampness" (TCM idea)
9 煮 *zhǔ* to boil
10 广州 *Guǎngzhōu* Guangzhou
11 下火 *xiàhuǒ* to reduce "inner heat" (TCM idea)

"This is Grandma's medicine chest," said Grandma with a smile as she poured her some water. "Your grandpa made it himself when he was young. It's been in use for nearly fifty years." 2

Xu Le went over and pulled open a little drawer. Inside were some small dried yellow flowers. She picked one up and sniffed it. It smelled lovely. "Grandma, what do you use all these things for?" At the mention of the medicine chest, Grandma's eyes lit up at once. "Oh, there are plenty of uses. When it's hot I make chrysanthemum tea; when there's a lot of rain I cook a soup to drive out the dampness; when autumn turns dry I boil pear water. For Guangzhou people, living well means following the seasons." 3

Xu Le nodded, but inside she didn't really agree. She had studied at medical school for three years and was used to looking at data, at experiments, at evidence. In her view, ideas like "driving out dampness" and "reducing inner heat" sounded nice enough, but they were hard to prove by scientific methods. 4

4 不过刚到外婆[†]家，她不想让老人不高兴，就把这些话留在了心里。

5 第一天晚上，外婆做了一桌子菜，还有一锅煲[‡]了三个小时的汤。外婆坐在对面，自己不怎么吃，只是看着她。“你脸色不太好，眼睛下面都是黑的。”外婆说，“学习再忙，也要好好睡觉。无论谁来我家，我都要先给他煲一锅汤。明天外婆再给你煲一个。”许乐[§]笑了：“外婆，我就是最近考试多，睡得晚一点儿，没什么。”她没把这件事放在心上[¶]，外婆却记住了。

凉茶[*]

6 广州[#]的夏天又热又湿。早上八点，太阳就已经很厉害了；下午常常突然下一场大雨，雨停了，空气反而更热。

† 外婆 *wàipó* grandma (mother's mother)
‡ 煲 *bāo* to slow-cook (Cantonese)
§ 许乐 *Xǔ Lè* Xu Le
¶ 放在心上 *fàngzàixīnshang* to take to heart
* 凉茶 *liángchá* herbal tea (Cantonese)
广州 *Guǎngzhōu* Guangzhou

But she had only just arrived, and she didn't want to upset the old lady, so she kept these thoughts to herself. 4

On the first evening, Grandma cooked a whole table of dishes, along with a pot of soup that had simmered for three hours. Grandma sat across from her, hardly eating anything herself, just watching her. "You don't look well, and it's all dark under your eyes," said Grandma. "However busy you are with your studies, you need to sleep properly. Whoever comes to my home, the first thing I do is cook them a pot of soup. Tomorrow Grandma will make you another one." Xu Le laughed. "Grandma, it's just that I've had a lot of exams lately and gone to bed a bit late. It's nothing." She didn't give it a second thought, but Grandma remembered. 5

Herbal Tea

Summer in Guangzhou is hot and humid. By eight in the morning the sun was already fierce; in the afternoon there was often a sudden downpour, and when the rain stopped the air was even hotter. 6

6 许乐[1]每天出一身汗，衣服好像从来没有干过。可是过了一段时间，她慢慢爱上了这里的雨，也爱上了雨后街上的那股[2]凉快。

7 有一天，外婆[3]看着她嘴边的一个小红点，认真地说：“你这是上火[4]了。”“外婆，这是天气太热，我又吃了太多辣的……”“那不就是上火嘛[5]。”外婆已经从药箱里拿出来几种东西，放进锅里煮[6]。半个小时以后，一碗黑黑的凉茶[7]放在了许乐面前。她喝了一口，苦得直摇头。“苦是苦，可是喝了舒服。”外婆说，“我小时候，街上到处都是凉茶店，大人小孩热了都去喝一碗。”

8 许乐看着那碗凉茶，不免有点儿为难。她不想喝，又不好意思说不。最后，她还是一口一口地喝完了。

1 许乐 *Xǔ Lè* Xu Le
2 股 *gǔ* (measure word for smells)
3 外婆 *wàipó* grandma (mother's mother)
4 上火 *shànghuǒ* to have "inner heat" (TCM idea)
5 嘛 *ma* (particle: obviously)
6 煮 *zhǔ* to boil
7 凉茶 *liángchá* herbal tea (Cantonese)

Xu Le sweated all over every day, and her clothes never seemed to dry. But after a while she slowly fell in love with the rain here, and with the coolness in the streets after it. 6

One day Grandma looked at a little red spot by Xu Le's mouth and said seriously, "You've got too much inner heat." "Grandma, that's just because the weather's so hot, and I've been eating too much spicy food..." "Well, isn't that exactly what inner heat is?" Grandma had already taken a few things out of the medicine chest and put them in a pot to boil. Half an hour later, a bowl of very dark herbal tea was set down in front of Xu Le. She took a sip, and it was so bitter she kept shaking her head. "It's bitter, all right, but you feel better after drinking it," said Grandma. "When I was little there were herbal tea shops all over the streets. Grown-ups and children alike went for a bowl whenever they felt hot." 7

Looking at the bowl of herbal tea, Xu Le couldn't help feeling a little awkward. She didn't want to drink it, yet she was too embarrassed to say no. In the end she drank it down, one mouthful at a time. 8

8 那天晚上，她躺在床上查资料，发现凉茶[1]在广东[2]已经有很长的历史，2006年还成了国家级非物质文化遗产[3]。可是它到底有没有效果，有多大的效果，研究并不多，结论也不一样。她在笔记本上写道："传统的东西未必都有用，可是也未必都没用。很多问题，我们还不清楚。"

9 接下来的几个星期，外婆[4]的汤一天也没停过。许乐[5]在附近一家社区医院实习，常常很晚才回家。星期一是冬瓜[6]汤，星期三是莲子[7]汤，星期五是一锅说不出名字的汤，里面有红枣[8]，也有一些许乐不认识的根和叶子。无论许乐多晚回来，桌上都有一碗汤在等着她。有时候她在外面吃过饭了，外婆也会说："喝一碗吧，就一碗。"

1 凉茶 *liángchá* herbal tea (Cantonese)
2 广东 *Guǎngdōng* Guangdong province
3 非物质文化遗产 *fēiwùzhì wénhuà yíchǎn* intangible cultural heritage
4 外婆 *wàipó* grandma (mother's mother)
5 许乐 *Xǔ Lè* Xu Le
6 冬瓜 *dōngguā* winter melon
7 莲子 *liánzǐ* lotus seed
8 红枣 *hóngzǎo* red date, jujube

That night she lay in bed looking things up, and found that herbal tea had a long history in Guangdong; in 2006 it had even been listed as national intangible cultural heritage. But as to whether it actually worked, and how much, there was not much research, and the conclusions differed. In her notebook she wrote: "Traditional things aren't necessarily all useful, but they aren't necessarily all useless either. There's a lot we still don't know." 8

For the next few weeks, Grandma's soups didn't stop for a single day. Xu Le was doing an internship at a community hospital nearby and often didn't get home until late. Monday was winter melon soup, Wednesday was lotus seed soup, and Friday was a pot of soup she couldn't put a name to, with red dates in it and some roots and leaves Xu Le didn't recognise. No matter how late Xu Le came back, there was always a bowl of soup on the table waiting for her. Sometimes she had already eaten out, but Grandma would still say, "Have a bowl. Just one bowl." 9

争论

10 真正的争论发生在七月底。那几天外婆[†]有点儿咳嗽[‡]，晚上也睡不好。许乐[§]让她去医院看看，外婆摆摆手说：“老毛病了，每年夏天都这样。喝几天罗汉果[¶]茶就好了。”许乐有点儿着急：“外婆，咳嗽的原因有很多种，自己在家是看不出来的。去医院检查一下，又不麻烦。”

11 “医院好是好，就是去一次要排半天队，医生看你两分钟，开一大堆药。”外婆说，“我活了七十多年，自己的身体我知道。”“可是您不是医生啊！”许乐的声音大了起来，“那些汤啊茶啊，到底有什么科学根据？有人做过实验吗？难道喝了几十年，就能证明它有用吗？”

12 话一说出口，许乐就后悔了。

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† 外婆 *wàipó* grandma (mother's mother)

‡ 咳嗽 *késou* to cough

§ 许乐 *Xǔ Lè* Xu Le

¶ 罗汉果 *luóhànguǒ* monk fruit

The Argument

The real argument happened at the end of July. For a few days Grandma had a bit of a cough, and she wasn't sleeping well at night either. Xu Le told her to go and see someone at the hospital, but Grandma waved it away. "It's an old problem. It's like this every summer. A few days of monk fruit tea and I'll be fine." Xu Le grew a little anxious. "Grandma, a cough can have lots of causes, and you can't tell which at home. Getting checked at the hospital isn't any trouble." 10

"Hospitals are fine and all, but every time you go you have to queue half the day, the doctor looks at you for two minutes and prescribes a huge pile of medicine," said Grandma. "I've lived more than seventy years. I know my own body." "But you're not a doctor!" Xu Le's voice rose. "All those soups and teas, what scientific basis do they actually have? Has anyone done experiments? Just because you've drunk them for decades, does that prove they work?" 11

The moment the words were out, Xu Le regretted them. 12

12 外婆[†]没有生气，只是看了她一会儿，然后慢慢地把桌上的碗收走了。“你是大学生，读的书比我多，”她低声说，“外婆说不过你。”那天晚上，两个人都没有再说话。许乐[‡]躺在床上，听见隔壁房间里一声一声的咳嗽[§]，怎么也睡不着。她觉得自己说的没有错，可是心里怎么也高兴不起来。

13 第二天早上，社区医院要组织几个医生去山里的村子给老人检查身体，许乐也要跟着去，两天以后才回来。出门前，外婆像平时一样，把一个装满了汤的保温杯放进她的包里：“路上喝。”许乐想说点儿什么，最后只说了一句：“外婆，您要是不舒服，一定给我打电话。”“知道了，知道了。”外婆笑着把她推出了门。

† 外婆 *wàipó* grandma (mother's mother)
‡ 许乐 *Xǔ Lè* Xu Le
§ 咳嗽 *késou* to cough

Grandma didn't get angry. She just looked at her for a while, then slowly 12
cleared the bowls from the table. "You're a university student, you've read more books than me," she said quietly. "Grandma can't win an argument with you." That evening neither of them said another word. Xu Le lay in bed listening to the coughing from the next room, one cough after another, and couldn't get to sleep however hard she tried. She felt that what she had said wasn't wrong, yet somehow she couldn't feel happy about it at all.

The next morning the community hospital was sending a few doctors to 13
villages in the hills to give the old people check-ups. Xu Le was going with them and wouldn't be back for two days. Before she left, Grandma, as always, put a thermos full of soup into her bag. "For the road." Xu Le wanted to say something, but in the end she said only, "Grandma, if you don't feel well, be sure to call me." "I know, I know." Grandma laughed and pushed her out of the door.

半夜的电话

14 第二天晚上，许乐[1]住在村里的一家小旅馆，白天她跟着医生看了四十多个老人，累得一躺下就睡着了。半夜一点多，手机突然响了，是外婆[2]。“乐乐[3]，睡了吧？”外婆的声音很哑[4]，“没事，没事……就是想听听你的声音。”

15 许乐一下子就醒了。她没有说话，把手机贴在耳朵上，仔细地听下去。外婆说得很慢，每说几个字就要停一下，呼吸又短又快，中间还有咳嗽[5]声。许乐学过这些，她听得出来，这不是什么“老毛病”。“外婆，您现在量一下体温[6]，好吗？体温计就在药箱最下面的抽屉[7]里。”过了一会儿，外婆说：“三十九度二。没事，我刚才喝了一碗凉茶[8]，睡一觉[9]就……”

1 许乐 *Xǔ Lè* Xu Le
2 外婆 *wàipó* grandma (mother's mother)
3 乐乐 *Lèle* Lele (Xu Le's pet name)
4 哑 *yǎ* hoarse
5 咳嗽 *késou* to cough
6 体温 *tǐwēn* body temperature
7 抽屉 *chōuti* drawer
8 凉茶 *liángchá* herbal tea (Cantonese)
9 觉 *jiào* (measure word for sleep)

The Midnight Phone Call

The next night Xu Le stayed at a small inn in the village. During the day she had gone round with the doctors and seen more than forty old people, and she was so tired that she fell asleep the moment she lay down. A little after one in the morning her phone suddenly rang. It was Grandma. "Lele, you're asleep, I suppose?" Grandma's voice was very hoarse. "It's nothing, nothing... I just wanted to hear your voice." 14

Xu Le was wide awake at once. Without a word, she pressed the phone to her ear and went on listening carefully. Grandma was speaking very slowly, stopping after every few words; her breathing was short and quick, with coughs in between. Xu Le had studied these things, and she could tell this was no "old problem". "Grandma, would you take your temperature now? The thermometer is in the bottom drawer of the medicine chest." After a while Grandma said, "Thirty-nine point two. It's nothing. I've just had a bowl of herbal tea, and after a good sleep I'll..." 15

16 “外婆[†]，您听我说。”许乐[‡]努力让自己的声音平静下来，“无论您觉得自己怎么样，现在都要去医院。我马上给陈[§]阿姨打电话，让她陪您去。我现在就回来。”电话那头安静了几秒钟。然后，外婆轻轻地说了一声：“好。”

17 许乐给住在外婆对门的陈阿姨打了电话，又叫醒了王医生。她穿上衣服就往外跑。王医生什么也没多问，帮她叫了一辆车。路上，许乐一直看着窗外黑黑的山，手里紧紧地拿着手机。她第一次觉得，两个小时的路这么长。

医院

18 许乐赶到医院的时候，天已经快亮了。外婆躺在急诊室[¶]的床上，手上打着点滴[*]，脸色比平时白了很多。

† 外婆 *wàipó* grandma (mother's mother)
‡ 许乐 *Xǔ Lè* Xu Le
§ 陈 *Chén* Chen (surname)
¶ 急诊室 *jízhěnshì* emergency room
* 点滴 *diǎndī* IV drip

"Grandma, listen to me." Xu Le tried hard to keep her voice calm. "However 16
you feel, you need to go to the hospital now. I'll call Auntie Chen right away and ask her to go with you. I'm coming back right now." The other end of the line was silent for a few seconds. Then Grandma said softly, "All right."

Xu Le phoned Auntie Chen, who lived across the landing from Grandma, 17
and then woke up Dr Wang. She threw on her clothes and ran out. Dr Wang didn't ask a single unnecessary question; he called a car for her. All the way, Xu Le kept looking out of the window at the dark hills, holding her phone tightly. For the first time in her life, a two-hour journey felt so long.

The Hospital

By the time Xu Le reached the hospital, it was almost dawn. Grandma was 18
lying on a bed in the emergency room with an IV drip in her hand, much paler than usual.

18 陈[†]阿姨看见许乐[‡]，拉着她的手说：“来了就好，来了就好。”检查结果出来了，外婆[§]得的是肺炎[¶]。医生说，老人生病的时候，有些表现不太明显，家里人很容易以为只是普通的咳嗽[*]。“来得还算及时，”医生对许乐说，“先住院治疗，观察几天。”

19 许乐长长地松了一口气，腿一下子软了。她坐在外面的椅子上，这才发现自己的手一直在发抖[#]。她是对的，外婆应该来医院，而且应该早点儿来。可是她一点儿也不觉得得意。她想起那天晚上自己大声说的话，想起外婆慢慢收碗的样子，心里很难受。

20 外婆在医院住了八天。头两天，她一直发烧，大部分时间都在睡觉。许乐请了假，无论白天还是晚上，都守在床边。

† 陈 *Chén* Chen (surname)
‡ 许乐 *Xǔ Lè* Xu Le
§ 外婆 *wàipó* grandma (mother's mother)
¶ 肺炎 *fèiyán* pneumonia
* 咳嗽 *késou* to cough
\# 发抖 *fādǒu* to tremble

When Auntie Chen saw Xu Le, she took her hand and said, "Thank goodness 18
you're here, thank goodness." The test results came back: Grandma had pneumonia. The doctor said that when older people fall ill, some of the signs aren't very obvious, and families can easily take it for an ordinary cough. "She came in reasonably early," the doctor told Xu Le. "She'll stay in hospital for treatment first, and we'll keep an eye on her for a few days."

Xu Le let out a long breath of relief, and her legs suddenly went weak. She 19
sat down on a chair outside, and only then noticed that her hands had been trembling the whole time. She had been right: Grandma should have come to the hospital, and should have come sooner. Yet she didn't feel the least bit pleased with herself. She remembered the things she had said so loudly that night, and the way Grandma had slowly cleared away the bowls, and she felt terrible.

Grandma stayed in hospital for eight days. For the first two days she had a 20
constant fever and slept most of the time. Xu Le took time off, and day or night she kept watch by the bed.

20 她给外婆[†]擦脸，扶外婆喝水，把每一次的体温[‡]都记下来。第三天早上，外婆的烧退了。她一醒来，看见许乐[§]靠在床边，第一句话就是："你几天没好好睡觉了？脸都瘦了。"许乐鼻子一酸，差点儿哭出来。外婆自己病成这样，第一眼看的居然还是她的脸色。

21 外婆有点儿不好意思，看着手上的针，小声说："难道我真的老了吗？以前喝一碗凉茶[¶]就好了。""外婆，您不老。"许乐拉着她的手，"可是生病了就要看医生，这跟老不老没有关系。"外婆想了想，点点头："好，听你的，以后哪儿不舒服，我就去医院。"过了一会儿，她又笑着说："不过，汤我还是要煲[*]下去的。"

22 那几天晚上，外婆睡着以后，许乐常常和妈妈打电话。妈妈在上海[#]工作，说好周末就飞过来。

† 外婆 *wàipó* grandma (mother's mother)
‡ 体温 *tǐwēn* body temperature
§ 许乐 *Xǔ Lè* Xu Le
¶ 凉茶 *liángchá* herbal tea (Cantonese)
* 煲 *bāo* to slow-cook (Cantonese)
\# 上海 *Shànghǎi* Shanghai

She wiped Grandma's face, helped her sit up to drink, and wrote down every temperature reading. On the morning of the third day, Grandma's fever went down. As soon as she woke and saw Xu Le leaning against the bed, the first thing she said was, "How many days is it since you last slept properly? Your face has got thin." Xu Le felt a sting in her nose and almost cried. Grandma was this ill herself, and yet the first thing she looked at was still Xu Le's face. 20

Grandma was a little embarrassed. Looking at the needle in her hand, she said quietly, "Have I really got old? A bowl of herbal tea used to be enough." "Grandma, you're not old." Xu Le held her hand. "But when you're ill you need to see a doctor. That has nothing to do with being old." Grandma thought it over and nodded. "All right, I'll do as you say. From now on, if anything feels wrong, I'll go to the hospital." After a moment she added with a smile, "But I'm still going to keep on making my soups." 21

Those nights, after Grandma had fallen asleep, Xu Le often talked to her mother on the phone. Her mother worked in Shanghai and had promised to fly down at the weekend. 22

22 说到外婆[†]的汤，妈妈在电话那头笑了：“你外婆啊，一辈子都是这样。我上中学的时候，每天晚上都要喝一碗她煲[‡]的汤。那时候我也觉得麻烦，觉得没什么用。”许乐[§]没有说话，等妈妈说下去。“后来我才明白，她煲汤的时候，其实一直在看着我们：谁的脸色不好，谁最近吃得少，谁心里有事。是什么汤，有时候并不重要。”

一碗汤

23 外婆出院那天，许乐先一个人回了家。她打开那个木头药箱，想找外婆说过的一个小本子。在最下面的抽屉[¶]里，体温计的旁边，她找到了。那是一本很旧的笔记本，第一页写着外公[*]的名字，下面是一行一行的小字：“三月，雨多，他腰疼。”再往后翻，是妈妈的小名，后来，是“乐乐[#]”。

† 外婆 *wàipó* grandma (mother's mother)
‡ 煲 *bāo* to slow-cook (Cantonese)
§ 许乐 *Xǔ Lè* Xu Le
¶ 抽屉 *chōuti* drawer
* 外公 *wàigōng* grandpa (mother's father)
乐乐 *Lèle* Lele (Xu Le's pet name)

When Grandma's soups came up, her mother laughed on the other end of the line. "Your grandma has been like that all her life. When I was at secondary school, I had to drink a bowl of her soup every evening. Back then I found it a nuisance too, and thought it didn't do much." Xu Le said nothing and waited for her mother to go on. "Only later did I understand. While she was making soup, she was actually watching us the whole time: who looked pale, who hadn't been eating much lately, who had something on their mind. What kind of soup it was sometimes didn't really matter." 22

A Bowl of Soup

On the day Grandma left hospital, Xu Le went home alone first. She opened the wooden medicine chest to look for a little notebook Grandma had mentioned. In the bottom drawer, next to the thermometer, she found it. It was a very old notebook. On the first page was Grandpa's name, and below it line after line of small writing: "March. Lots of rain. His back aches." Further on came her mother's childhood name, and later on, "Lele". 23

24 写着“乐乐[†]”的那一页，日期是她来广州[‡]的第一天：“乐乐来了。眼睛下面是黑的，太瘦，晚上睡得晚。汤少放盐。”再往下：“乐乐嘴边起了红点，这几天不太开心，可能是想家了。”“乐乐今天回来晚，没吃饭，汤留着。”许乐[§]一页一页地看下去，眼泪终于掉了下来。这些天，她一直在研究外婆[¶]的汤里有什么、有没有用，却从来没想过，外婆煲[*]汤的时候心里在想什么。原来外婆每天都在看着她，比她自己看得还要仔细。

25 汤里的东西，未必都有外婆说的那些作用。可是那一碗一碗的汤，让一家人每天坐在一起，让一个人去注意另[#]一个人累不累、瘦没瘦、开不开心。许乐想，无论科学最后怎么说，这种关心都是真的。医院能治病，可是医院不会每天晚上等你回家。

† 乐乐 *Lèle* Lele (Xu Le's pet name)
‡ 广州 *Guǎngzhōu* Guangzhou
§ 许乐 *Xǔ Lè* Xu Le
¶ 外婆 *wàipó* grandma (mother's mother)
* 煲 *bāo* to slow-cook (Cantonese)
另 *lìng* another

The page headed "Lele" was dated her first day in Guangzhou: "Lele has come. Dark under the eyes, too thin, goes to bed late. Less salt in the soup." Further down: "Lele has a red spot by her mouth. Not very happy these days, perhaps homesick." "Lele back late today, hasn't eaten. Keep soup for her." Xu Le read on, page after page, until at last her tears fell. All this time she had been studying what was in Grandma's soups and whether they worked, yet she had never once wondered what Grandma was thinking while she made them. So Grandma had been watching her every day, more closely than she had ever watched herself. 24

The things in the soups did not necessarily all do what Grandma said they did. But bowl after bowl, those soups brought a family to the table together every day, and made one person notice whether another was tired, had got thinner, was happy or not. Xu Le thought that whatever science might finally say, this kind of care was real. A hospital can treat illness, but a hospital won't wait up for you to come home every night. 25

26 那天下午，许乐[†]照着本子上的方法，在厨房里煲[‡]了她人生中的第一锅汤。她还不太会看火，汤有点儿咸。外婆[§]回到家，喝了一口，笑了起来："咸是咸了点儿，可是好喝。"

27 晚上，外婆睡了。许乐坐在药箱前面，打开那个旧本子，翻到新的一页，认真地写上："八月十五日，外婆出院。医生说一个月以后再去医院检查一次，别忘了。外婆今天精神不错，喝了两碗汤，笑了三次。"写完，她把本子放回抽屉[¶]，轻轻地关上。窗外又下起了雨。厨房里，那锅汤还是热的。

† 许乐 *Xǔ Lè* Xu Le
‡ 煲 *bāo* to slow-cook (Cantonese)
§ 外婆 *wàipó* grandma (mother's mother)
¶ 抽屉 *chōuti* drawer

That afternoon, following the method in the notebook, Xu Le made the first 26
pot of soup of her life in the kitchen. She wasn't very good at watching the heat yet, and the soup came out a little salty. Grandma came home, took a sip and burst out laughing. "It's a bit salty, all right, but it's good."

In the evening, after Grandma had gone to sleep, Xu Le sat in front of the 27
medicine chest, opened the old notebook, turned to a fresh page and carefully wrote: "15 August. Grandma left hospital. The doctor says she should go back for another check in a month; don't forget. Grandma in good spirits today. Had two bowls of soup, laughed three times." When she had finished, she put the notebook back in the drawer and gently closed it. Outside the window it had started to rain again. In the kitchen, the pot of soup was still warm.